

Kitchen & *Kettle*

# Simple Homekeeping Guide

INTERACTIVE EDITION

Cleaning recipes from kitchen  
ingredients, simple routines, and  
honest guidance. Check off tasks as  
you go.

## Why fewer products?

Most of what a house needs for cleaning can be handled with three things: soap, an acid, and a mild abrasive. The rest is knowing when to use each one — and when a commercial product does the job better.

This isn't about avoiding "chemicals." Everything is chemicals. It's about fewer bottles under your sink, understanding what's in them, and spending less money.

## The seven-ingredient cleaning pantry

### White vinegar

A mild acid. Dissolves mineral deposits, cuts grease, deodorizes.

*Glass, counters, bathroom, laundry rinse, coffee maker.*

#### HONEST NOTE

*Does not disinfect. Use for cleaning (removing dirt), not sanitizing. If someone is sick, use something stronger.*

### Baking soda

A mild abrasive and deodorizer. Scrubs without scratching.

*Sinks, tubs, stovetops, oven, deodorizing, laundry booster.*

#### HONEST NOTE

*The baking soda + vinegar fizz is not what cleans — it's just the two neutralizing each other. Scrub with baking soda, rinse, then wipe with vinegar. Don't mix them at the same time.*

### Castile soap (liquid) or plain bar soap

A true soap from plant oils or gentle fats. Cuts through dirt and grease. Liquid castile is convenient; a plain bar like Ivory or Dove Sensitive works just as well — grate and dissolve in warm water, or rub a damp cloth on the bar.

*All-purpose spray, dish soap, hand soap, floors, laundry (soft water).*

#### HONEST NOTE

*Castile can irritate some people's skin. If it bothers you, switch to a plain unscented bar (Ivory, Dove Sensitive). Cleans just as well and many find it gentler. Don't mix any soap with vinegar — they cancel out.*

### Citric acid

A stronger, odorless acid. Excellent descaler.

*Dishwasher, washing machine, kettle, bathroom fixtures.*

# The seven-ingredient cleaning pantry (continued)

|                                                                                                                                                                                                               |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <div><b>Salt (coarse)</b></div> <div>Abrasive and absorbent. Good for stubborn residue.</div> <div><i>Cast iron, cutting boards, oven spills, wine stains.</i></div>                                          | <div><b>Hydrogen peroxide (3%)</b></div> <div>Oxidizing cleaner and mild disinfectant.</div> <div><i>Stain removal, cutting board sanitizing, grout, laundry.</i></div> <div><div><b>HONEST NOTE</b></div><div><i>Keep in dark bottle. Don't mix with vinegar (creates irritant).</i></div></div> |
| <div><b>Isopropyl alcohol (70%)</b></div> <div>Fast-evaporating solvent. Cuts grease, disinfects, leaves no residue.</div> <div><i>Glass cleaner, electronics, sticky residue, hand sanitizer base.</i></div> |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |

# Cleaning Recipes

## All-Purpose Spray

*Counters, tables, sinks, most hard surfaces. Daily use.*

1 cup water • 1 cup white vinegar • optional: 10 drops essential oil

1. Combine in a spray bottle. Shake before each use.
2. Spray surface. Wipe with a clean cloth.

Do not use on marble, granite, or natural stone.

My notes on this recipe:

## Soft Scrub (sinks, tubs, stovetops)

Baking soda • liquid soap or plain bar (castile, Ivory, or Dove) • water

1. Sprinkle baking soda onto the wet surface.
2. Add a few drops of liquid soap, or rub a damp cloth on a bar of mild soap.
3. Scrub with damp cloth. Rinse thoroughly.

My notes on this recipe:

## Glass & Mirror Cleaner

½ cup isopropyl alcohol (70% or 50%) • ½ cup water

1. Combine in spray bottle. Shake gently.
2. Spray onto glass. Wipe with microfiber cloth or newspaper.

Alcohol cuts grease and evaporates fast — zero streaks. No alcohol? ¼ cup vinegar + 1 cup water + 1 tsp cornstarch works too.

My notes on this recipe:

# Cleaning Recipes (cont.)

## Floor Cleaner

1 gallon hot water • ¼ cup white vinegar • 2–3 drops mild liquid soap (optional)

- 1. Combine in bucket. Mop as usual.
- 2. No need to rinse — vinegar residue evaporates.

My notes on this recipe:

## Oven Cleaner (non-toxic, requires elbow grease)

Baking soda • water • white vinegar (for final wipe)

- 1. Make a paste of baking soda and water. Spread over surfaces.
- 2. Let sit overnight (at least 8 hours).
- 3. Scrub with damp cloth. Spray vinegar on stubborn spots.

My notes on this recipe:

## Products Worth Buying

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Some jobs are better handled by a bottle someone else formulated. These are the two I keep under my sink.

### **Seventh Generation**

Plant-based, dye-free, fragrance-free. Their dish soap, laundry detergent, and all-purpose spray are formulated without anything harsh — and they're septic-safe. When you don't want to make it yourself but still want a short, readable ingredient list, this is the bottle I reach for.

### **Bar Keepers Friend**

An oxalic-acid cleanser in powder form — a mild abrasive that removes hard-water stains, rust, and tarnish without bleach. One can replace stainless-steel cleaner, porcelain polish, and cooktop scrub. Wet the surface, shake on powder, wipe off. Septic-safe in normal household use.

*Also worth buying: toilet bowl cleaner, laundry detergent for hard water, dishwasher detergent, and a proper disinfectant for when someone is sick. This isn't absolutism — it's knowing when DIY wins and when it doesn't.*

# Cleaning Rhythms

[Clear checks](#)

*A rhythm is not a schedule. If you miss a day, pick up where you left off.*

## DAILY (5–15 MINUTES)

- ☐ Make the bed (or just straighten covers — close enough)
- ☐ Wipe kitchen counters after dinner
- ☐ Wash dishes or load dishwasher
- ☐ Quick sweep of kitchen floor (the crumb zone)
- ☐ Put away 5 things that aren't where they belong

## WEEKLY (ANY DAY YOU HAVE ENERGY)

- ☐ Clean bathroom: mirror, counter, sink, toilet, shower spray
- ☐ Change towels and kitchen cloths
- ☐ Vacuum or sweep all floors
- ☐ Mop kitchen and bathroom floors
- ☐ Take out trash and recycling
- ☐ Wipe down kitchen appliances (outside)
- ☐ One load of laundry, start to finish

## MONTHLY

- ☐ Clean inside microwave
- ☐ Wipe cabinet fronts and handles
- ☐ Clean washing machine (empty run with vinegar)
- ☐ Dust baseboards, light fixtures, ceiling corners
- ☐ Check and toss expired fridge items
- ☐ Wash one unusual item: shower curtain, bath mat, pillow covers

### IF YOU ONLY DO ONE THING

*A clean kitchen and a clean bathroom make a house feel functional. Skip everything else if you're overwhelmed.*

### COMPANY IN TWENTY MINUTES

*Trash sweep — one bag, every room. Wipe the bathroom mirror, counter, and toilet lid. Clear the kitchen counters. Fluff the couch cushions. Light a candle. Nobody's inspecting your baseboards.*

# Laundry & Simple Care

## LAUNDRY THAT LASTS

- **Cold water for most things.** Warm for towels and bedding.
- **Less detergent than the bottle says.** Start with half.
- **Air dry when you can.** The dryer is the hardest thing you do to your clothes.
- **Don't overwash.** Jeans, sweaters, outer layers — hang to air out between wears.

## STAIN REMOVAL THAT WORKS

| STAIN             | WHAT TO USE                    | METHOD                                                                 |
|-------------------|--------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Blood             | Cold water + hydrogen peroxide | Rinse in cold water immediately. Dab peroxide. Never hot water.        |
| Red wine          | Salt, then cold water          | Cover with salt to absorb. Rinse with cold water. Launder.             |
| Grease / oil      | Dish soap or baking soda       | Rub a drop of dish soap into stain. Or cover with baking soda.         |
| Coffee / tea      | Cold water, vinegar if needed  | Rinse immediately. Dab vinegar on stubborn spots.                      |
| Tomato / berry    | Cold water, then sunlight      | Rinse, rub with detergent, lay in direct sun. UV breaks down pigments. |
| Sweat / deodorant | White vinegar soak             | Soak 30 min before washing. Prevents yellowing.                        |

## TWICE-A-YEAR RESET

| *The stuff nobody remembers until it's overdue. Pick a weekend in spring and fall — or whenever the mood strikes.*

### WHEN THE WEATHER WARMS

- Wash windows inside and out
- Wash or dry-clean curtains
- Flip and rotate mattresses
- Pull out appliances — clean behind fridge and stove
- Deep clean the oven
- Wash pillows and duvets

### BEFORE THE COLD SETS IN

- Clean gutters or check drainage
- Wash blankets and comforters
- Check weatherstripping around doors and windows
- Rotate pantry — use up old, restock
- Move heavy furniture — vacuum underneath
- Dust ceiling fans and light fixtures

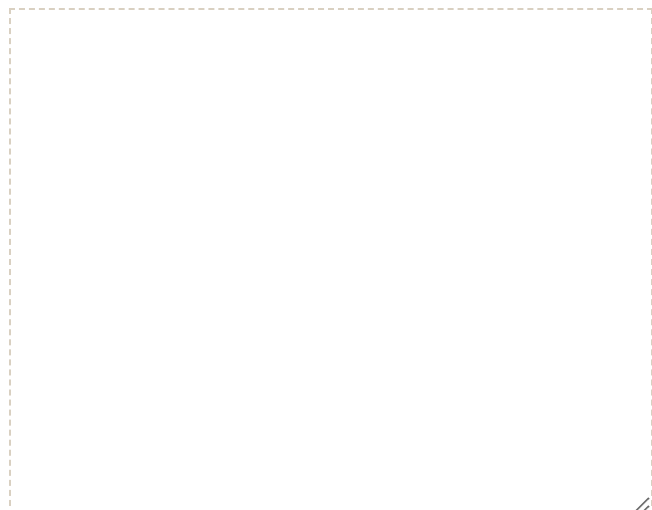


## A note on homekeeping

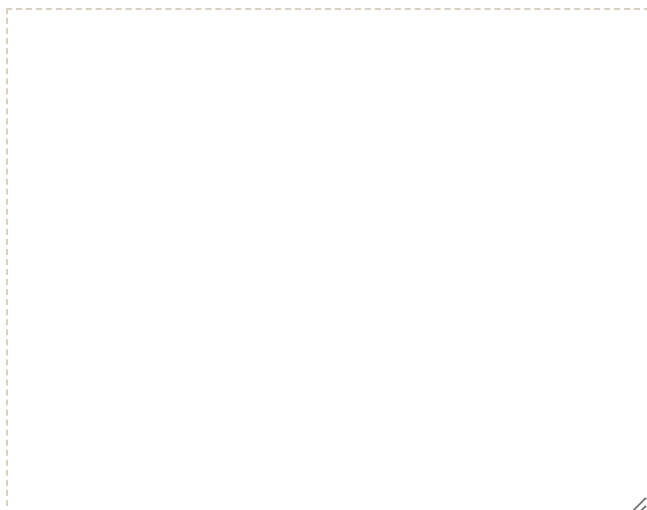
A clean house is not a moral achievement. A messy house is not a personal failure. These are just systems for making a space that supports your life.

If you try one thing, make the all-purpose spray. Thirty seconds to mix, costs almost nothing, replaces three bottles under your sink.

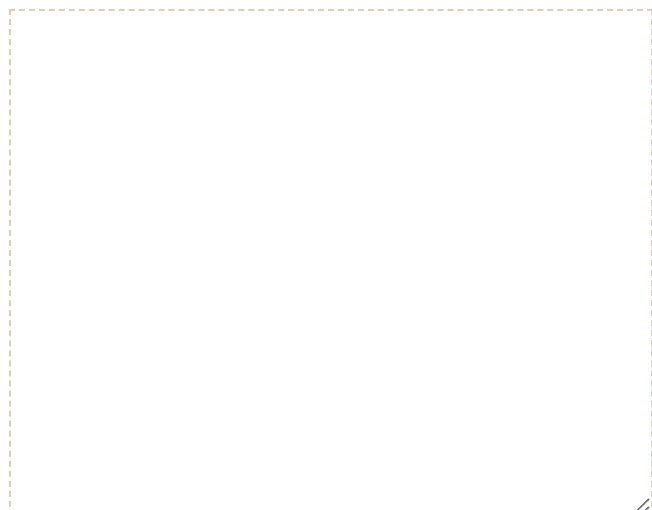
### CLEANING RHYTHM THAT WORKS FOR ME



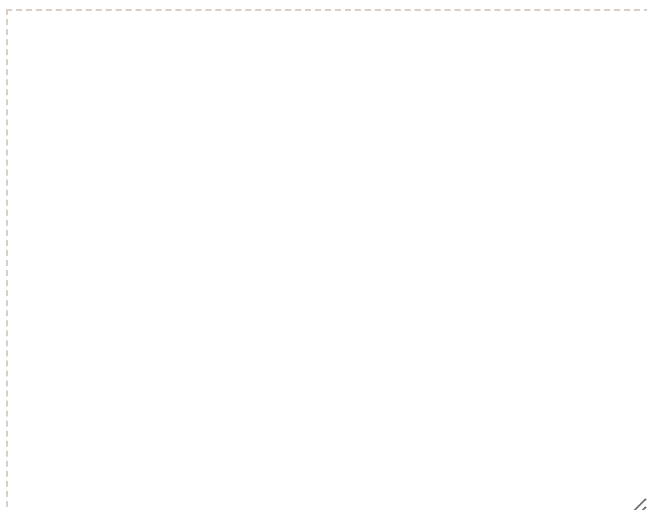
### PRODUCTS I STOPPED BUYING



### THINGS I STILL BUY (AND WHY)



### SEASONAL CLEANING NOTES



Kitchen & Kettle • Works because it works.

## **A home that works**

Cleaning isn't a moral test. A home doesn't need to be spotless to be good. What it needs is a few reliable systems, a handful of ingredients that do more than one job, and the confidence to ignore the rest of the cleaning aisle.

*Works because it works.*

Kitchen & Kettle

A quieter way to run a kitchen.